

A FIVE-YEAR BONANZA

Promising "progressive unfoldment", the PM spelt out his agenda for a third term

- India will become the third largest economic power globally
- In an uncertain world, India will be a stable, capable and strong force
- Our infrastructure boom will see new heights
- Indian Railways will see a massive transformation with expansion of bullet train, Vande Bharat services
- India's waterways will see unprecedented use
- Semiconductor, hydrogen missions will see impact on the ground
- The space sector will take flight; Gaganyaan's success will ensure it
- New sectors will open up opportunities for the youth
- Solar power will reach every home
- Record growth in EV manufacturing
- Defence exports will set fresh records
- Decisive policies and decisions will shape our future

cartoons of R.K. Laxman. I have lived with the common man. Governments never valued his time, nor understood his problems. So, we made the common man's ease of living the top priority of our government.

I want to share some statistics. Earlier, to get a passport made, it would take, on an average, 50 days; you would also have to bribe the local policeman, make 50 calls, ask 50 people to put in a word. Today, it takes, on average, 5-6 days for a passport to be delivered to your home. How did this change come about? The officers are the same, so are the files, even the budget. It came because the government laid stress on ease of living. We also provided infrastructural support. Before 2014, there were only 77 passport seva kendras in the country. Today, there are nearly 525. You will see such changes all around. Before 2014, the average time for income tax refund was 93 days. Now, the average time has come down to under 10 days. Before 2014, the average waiting time at our toll plazas was more than 12 minutes. Now, after the introduction of FASTag, it is 30-40 seconds.

Our penal codes were a legacy of the colonial era. At their core was punishment, not justice, because they stemmed from the British mentality. They had to be replaced. We have now made them justice-centric in keeping with our governance model. The three new codes that have been passed will help even the ordinary citizen get justice faster. In the past 10 years, our government has abolished more than 1,500 old laws, many of which were of colonial vintage.

I often say citizens should feel neither the pressure nor the absence of government. The poor should not feel there is no one to help them in their time of crisis. The government should be present where necessary, but not meddle in every aspect of life. If I succeed in my mission up to 2047, there will be no government in the common man's life. He will have the freedom to live his own life, to have the whole sky to give wings to his dreams.

For this ease of living, we have eliminated more than 40,000 unnecessary compliances. We are making an effort to ensure that the common man doesn't have to visit any government office and stand in long queues, whether for the electricity bill, house tax, water tax, property work or scholarship. Dozens of such tasks can now be done online. You will not see any lines at the railway station ay more. The world has changed.

Ease of living does not mean just the expansion of such services. Ease of living improves only when the poor and the middle class have money in their pockets. How our government schemes are helping people save is a case study in itself. In 2014, you had to pay tax on annual income of Rs 2 lakh. Today, people earning less than Rs 7 lakh do not have to pay a single rupee in tax. Because of this, citizens get to save Rs 2.5 lakh crore in direct taxes.

Several times, the government gives discounts that the common man is not even aware of. For example, in the past 10 years, a discount of Rs 4.5 lakh crore has been given on railway tickets alone. The poor and middle class have saved this money. The Swachh Bharat Abhiyan is also helping the poor and middle class save money. Due to this campaign, the spread of many diseases has been curbed. A study has revealed that Swachh Bharat Abhiyan is helping the poor save more than Rs 60,000 crore every year. Otherwise, they would have had to spend this money on treating these diseases. Likewise, the Ayushman Bharat scheme has helped the poor save Rs 1 lakh crore, which they would have had to spend for